

unutterably valueless, often keeps the tears inside; they are shunted into ulcers and covered by accumulations of overweight . . . Anyone who challenges him to reconsider his priorities—a wife, a friend, a management consultant—becomes the enemy. He may try every form of self-delusion, retreat into drinking or hypochondria, cast his wife as a monster, abandon his family, almost anything to forestall looking into the mess inside.

When I turned 35 I hadn't reached the state Sheehy describes. But I had just been offered a lateral transfer. When the regional partner told me about the job, he emphasized that careers can seem to go flat at times. "You don't always go up," he told me at lunch. He moved his hand across the table in an upward motion. "Sometimes you go like this," he said. He moved his hand horizontally across the table before going up.

General Motors, Procter & Gamble, Exxon, and other companies announce new top executives every now and again. The new executives are nearly always people in their 50s or 60s who've spent thirty or more years with their companies. I wonder how those executives, the top 1 percent, stuck it out. And I wonder how the other 99 percent, those who reached plateaus and worked for decades more with little or no career growth, stuck it out. As the Bob Dylan song says, "He not busy being born is busy dying."

I decided that my career was keeping me "busy dying." I opted for the exciting challenge of a new life.

## **THE COMPANY WILL GET ALONG WITHOUT YOU**

It's curious that executive crisis is independent of what level of success you've achieved. You may be chairman of Peat Marwick or junior partner of a small firm. You may be the top guy in IBM, the second guy, the one-hundredth guy, or the ten-thousandth guy. You may have two secretaries,